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Hotel Central waking up from a long slumber

By Nelson Moura

A revamped and rejuvenated Hotel Central, one of the city's iconic historical hotels, is set to open its doors in the first quarter of 2024. The owner of the property, Simon Sio from the Lek Heng Group, tells Macau Business the historical hotel underwent a careful restoration process aimed at preserving its history and charm, while helping to boost the hospitality offerings in the Senado Square and San Ma Lo area.

Nelson Moura



The almost 100-year-old Hotel Central on Avenida de Almeida Ribeiro is preparing to open to the public after undergoing a series of renovation works.

The Macau Historical Centre property, which a consortium paid MOP1.5 billion (US\$186.4 million) for in early 2016, is slated to begin operating in the first quarter of 2024 and offer 114 new rooms.

Its new owner, Simon Sio, manager of the local property developer Lek Heng Group, who spent his childhood in the same area, has always reiterated that the revamp would help preserve the hotel's history and help revitalize the Senado Square area.

The hotel first opened in 1928, with the then-six-story hotel named Presidente at the time, before being renamed Central in 1932.

In 1937, the hotel received investment from the Tai Heng Company, at the time the exclusive concessionaire for the operation of games of chance, controlled by traders Fu Tak Lam and Kou Ho Neng.



"The renovation of Hotel Central followed the principle of 'restoring the old to the old'. We used durable

and long-lasting materials, regardless of the cost, to enable the hotel to keep its former glory for another century” – Simon Sio, owner of Hotel Central

Tai Heng renovated the hotel and, that same year, opened the Central Hotel and Casino, offering gaming space on its fifth and seventh floors.

More floors were built in 1942, following a request to the Government of Portugal, reaching a total of 12, which helped make not just the tallest building in the city but also of the entire Portuguese overseas colonial territories.

However, in the early 1960s, when STDM received the main gaming concession in Macau, the Hotel Central casino was forced to close, initiating the hotel's decline and several decades of abandonment.

"In 2009, I learned that some shareholders of the hotel wanted to sell their shares. Recognising the hotel's rarity, historical value, and business potential, I contacted them. After seven years of hard negotiations, I finally purchased all the shares of the Hotel Central in 2016 for almost MOP1.5 billion," Sio told Macau Business.

"It took an additional three years to obtain the necessary approvals for the restoration and redevelopment of the hotel. Construction began at the end of 2019, coinciding with the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic."



Recovering an old giant

Hotel Central required three primary types of rehabilitation and reconstruction work: foundation strengthening, structural reinforcement, and interior redecoration.

According to Sio, the hotel underwent expansion in stages from the mid-1930s to the early 1940s, increasing from its original seven floors to its current 11 floors without any improvements to the foundations, which lacked piles.

Over the years, the foundations had to bear heavy loads, and the hotel suffered serious structural damage due to poor maintenance; therefore, extensive repairs were necessary before the hotel could reopen.

"After consulting with experts and scholars from various fields, I decided to restore and reinforce the hotel from the foundation, regardless of the cost. I used a self-developed method of pile drilling to drive 129 piles under the original foundation without piles to significantly increase the hotel's overall load capacity," the developer pointed out.

The structure above ground level also had to be rebuilt by enlarging the cross-section to make the entire building more stable from the bottom up.

Furthermore, as a result of outdated construction technologies and materials, the exterior walls of Hotel Central have become fragile over time, posing safety risks after nearly a century of exposure to the elements.

To ensure the stability and durability of the wall structure, the Lek hang construction team utilised a special process to fix the interior of the external walls with stainless steel mesh and anchoring. Upon completion of the project, the external walls became more stable and highly waterproof.

Preserving the charm

The property is considered one of the architectural cornerstones of the complexes and sites in that area according to the Cultural Heritage Protection Law.

This implied a careful collaboration between the developer and the Cultural Affairs Bureau, to make sure that the main elements of the hotels facade were kept.

The hotel's main billboard letters on its rooftop, for example, were also kept in their original size and font.

"The renovation of Hotel Central followed the principle of 'restoring the old to the old'. We used durable and long-lasting materials, regardless of the cost, to enable the hotel to keep its former glory for another century," Sio highlighted.

"After restoration and revitalization, Hotel Central will have 11 storeys and 114 rooms. Each pair of floors will be designed to reflect a specific era, featuring a nostalgic theme and highly intelligent, eco-friendly facilities."

The rooms located on the 5th and 6th floors will be inspired in the 1920s, with those on the 7th and 8th floors inspired in the 1930s, and those on the 9th and 10th floors inspired in the 1940s.

The hotel formerly held casinos on the 5th and 7th floors of the building and was the first building in Macau with elevators.

In the revamped property the first to third floors will be reserved for commercial use, with the lobby on the fourth and the about 100 hotel rooms to be included located from the 6th floor up.

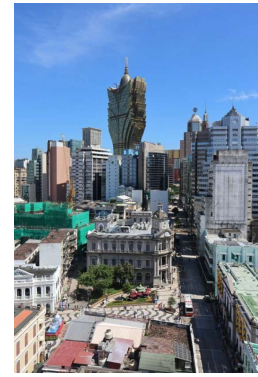
The ground floor of Hotel Central will also feature a gallery showcasing the 100-year history of Avenida de Almeida Ribeiro and the hotel through different pictures and an introduction by Ieng Weng Fat, a renowned Macau historian.

One of the most enticing new attractions the revamped property will offer to tourists visiting the area will be its rooftop promenade on the 11th floor which will allow guests and visitors a rare 360-degree view of the city's historical centre.

"It is also important to mention that the Palace Restaurant on the 4th floor will be reopening to serve the hotel's auxiliary needs and support Macau in promoting itself as the 'Creative City of Gastronomy,'" he added.

One thing is sure, the new hotel will not provide a casino as it did for many years, when it received a steady flow of adventurers, pirates, criminals, and gamblers from all corners of the world.

In the end, Sio concluded that he hoped Hotel Central could set a new standard in the heart of Avenida de Almeida Ribeiro and serve as a positive example for the revitalisation of Macau's historic district.



Hotel Central has amassed many intriguing and curious facts during its 100-year history



- The hotel was officially inaugurated in 1928 as Hotel Presidente, in a grand ceremony presided over by the then-governor of the city, Tamagnini Barbosa.
- At the time, the hotel had 80 rooms and cost about half a million patacas to build.
- Upon its opening, newspapers at the time highlighted some of the main attractions, including the hotel's ten dining rooms, roof garden, two elevators with a capacity for 9 people each, a "splendid" cinematograph room, and the fact that it housed a refrigerator—a novelty in the city at the time. According to the report, crowds gathered to use the elevators to go up to the hotel's rooftop and enjoy the view. The electric system for the hotel and its elevators was provided by Melco, not yet a gaming concessionaire, but an electricity company at the time.
- The property also offered billiard rooms, a hairdresser, and its dance ballrooms, including the renowned Grand Central Cabaret, which opened in 1937 on its 6th floor. It operated every day from 9:00 pm to 2:00 am and featured a dancing show with Filipino performers. Many of China's most famous dance troupes passed through its ballroom after being forced to leave the country following the Japanese invasion and the Second World War.

- When tycoon Huo Zhiting built the International Hotel at the end of San Ma Lou, he ordered it to have nine floors so that when it opened in 1941, it would be taller than the Central Hotel. This prompted those responsible for Hotel Central to immediately order an expansion and renovation of the building, adding two more floors by 1942 and making it once again the tallest structure in Macau with 11 floors.

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